

Chapter 112-1: Recognition

According to usual convention, the Demon Extermination Conference typically began with displays from each sect, and this time was no exception. After the enormous Alchemy Cauldron Manor was filled, the main doors slowly closed, and the starlight overhead appeared even more brilliant in the noise.

A golden dragon formed from converging streams of light floated over everyone's heads, and several women dressed in Western Region dance attire appeared at the center of the high platform. They swayed their bodies to the gentle music, and exotic fragrances scattered toward the crowd along with their flying skirts, drawing waves of applause.

"As expected of the Blissful Union Sect—any disciple they randomly pick is exceptionally beautiful!" came the delighted praise of a young girl from the Celestial Profound Sword Sect's area in the distance. It was the red-faced girl from that day at Flying Swallow Residence.

She looked back at her senior martial brothers and sisters sitting properly and pouted.

"I should have joined the Blissful Union Sect if I'd known." She rested her chin on her palm. "Our sect has too many rules—no drinking, no finding men, even watching dancers has to be done properly."

The youth who had been with her that day chuckled: "Blissful Union Sect? Do you know how they cultivate?"

"How could I not know?" The girl rolled her eyes.

The youth was about to say more when he looked up and saw the sect leader approaching. He quickly withdrew his gaze and sat properly with eyes on his nose and nose on his heart. However, the girl didn't notice and continued chattering away.

Thus she received a flick on the forehead right there, holding her head and crying out in pain.

Sect Leader Tang Wenshu was walking by when he saw a restless head from afar, so he reached out in warning before continuing forward with a serious expression.

Zhou Yantan and Elder Songxiang, following behind him, each gave the girl another flick before completely ignoring her wailing and continuing forward with their hands behind their backs.

"Sect Leader, do you think that Ning Fuyi is really here? But our security is tight—only those with invitations can enter. How could she have snuck in?" Elder Songxiang asked with his hands tucked in his sleeves.

Tang Wenshu shook his head: "I also think Penglai's move doesn't make sense, but what we say doesn't count. Let them do as they please. We just need to maintain security and leave the rest to fate."

"Elder Songxiang, we also need to be extra careful about that Chuwei Hall." He added another reminder before turning back to his pavilion.

Elder Songxiang bowed in acknowledgment, then straightened his old back and pulled over Zhou Yantan, who was standing with her head down listening: "Tan'er, I have an important matter for you to handle."

"Please instruct me, Master." Zhou Yantan bowed.

"You know that this Divine Venerable is my great-grandmother. But since her resurrection, she hasn't seen anyone, and I can't express my filial piety, which troubles me greatly." Elder Songxiang said as he took out a crabapple jade box from his sleeve and placed it in Zhou Yantan's hands.

"This contains a Heartless Stone that I obtained from a high monk. It specifically counters all kinds of attachments and delusions in this world. For those who cultivate the Heartless Way, it has miraculous effects and can greatly increase their cultivation."

"I can't leave here, so you'll present it to the Divine Venerable on my behalf. Remember not to open the box in front of others." Elder Songxiang said kindly.

Zhou Yantan carefully accepted the jade box, nodded, and held it in her arms. She looked up toward the distant pavilion hidden beyond the lights, where that graceful silhouette still stood behind the gauze curtain, cold and ethereal.

Zhou Yantan's heart skipped a beat, and she quickly lowered her head, not daring to look again.

The Alchemy Cauldron Manor, as large as an entire island, housed thousands of people and thus thousands of different thoughts, each tangled and chaotic in their own way.

At this moment, one dance had ended on the high platform. The entire venue erupted in applause and cheers as the women transformed into flowing light and retreated. Then came the sound of drums, and two rows of bald men holding staffs took the stage, the rhythm of their staffs hitting the ground harmonizing with the drum beats.

At the same time, the men's loud shouts joined the drum beats, horns sounded, the drumbeats gradually intensified, and the staffs in their hands spun with the increasingly rapid drum rhythm, making everyone's blood boil with excitement.

Just from seeing those shining bald heads, everyone knew it was the Clear Void Sect. The surrounding applause thundered like lightning, and with the addition of string music, everyone felt as if they were witnessing a battlefield with two armies clashing, all straightening their backs and staring with wide eyes.

In several high pavilions, the sect leaders stood at the edges of their pavilions, looking down at the high platform. The Enchantress Handin of the Blissful Union Sect covered her lips and laughed softly: "Worthy of the Clear Void Sect—such excellent staff techniques."

"Mere trivial skills, naturally can't compare to Fairy Handin." Master Feiguang of the Clear Void Sect pressed his palms together.

"What do you all think that Chuwei Hall is up to? The Demon Extermination Conference has been going on for a while, and they haven't even pulled down a curtain. Are they that unsightly?" Li Handin asked, twisting her waist as she looked around.

"Hard to say." Sect Leader Hua Hong of the Flying Flower Sect shook his head, but then smiled slyly. "However, I have a method to try that might make that unsightly Chuwei Hall show their face."

"What does Divine Venerable Chu Ling think?" Hua Hong turned toward the pavilion at the far edge, speaking craftily.

Chu Qingqiu had long heard their words. She stood behind the curtain for a long time before speaking: "I'm feeling unwell. You all decide as you see fit."

Though she said this, her gaze was still drawn to look across, where melodious music continued from behind the thick gauze curtain, seemingly unaffected by the increasingly resounding drum beats.

"Since the Divine Venerable doesn't object, what about the family heads?" Hua Hong looked to the other side, where apart from the Liu family who weren't present, the other three great families all stood in their pavilions.

Jiang Li's heart stirred, but just as she stepped back two paces, she heard Jiang Wuying cough once, forcing her to stop in place and grip her shawl tightly.

Jiang Wuying had been feeling better recently and thus controlled her even more strictly, barely allowing her to leave his sight. Though she wanted to warn Chu Qingqiu, she was powerless to do so.

She kept patting her palms and looking up to pray to heaven, hoping no trouble would occur today.

Finally, Gongsun Mo of the Gongsun family smiled and spoke: "We have no objections."

Hearing this, Hua Hong finally shook the bell at his side, and crisp bell sounds slowly rippled out from his palm, causing the densely packed disciples below to look up.

"Everyone, since each sect has prepared songs and martial arts, though our Flying Flower Sect isn't skilled in these areas, we also want to perform and add to the excitement."

After speaking, Hua Hong raised his hand, and an exquisite paper crane flew from his palm, slowly flying to the top of the high platform and transforming to the size of a real crane. Though the paper crane didn't look like a real bird, its wings were flexible and strong, appearing lifelike.

Then the paper crane suddenly let out a long cry, sounding like a real crane's call, spreading auspicious omens. Countless silver powder fell from high above, causing everyone to cheer continuously.

At the same time, the paper crane spread its wings and circled the entire Alchemy Cauldron Manor. The silver powder sparkled brilliantly in the lights like scattered starlight, accompanied by the drums and music on stage—a scene of unprecedented grandeur.

Then, Hua Hong's fingertips lightly flicked behind his back, and three silver threads controlling the paper crane appeared in his palm.

So the paper crane suddenly cried out and swiftly flew toward the tightly closed gauze curtain in the distance.

The paper crane moved too fast for most disciples to see clearly. Only a few with high magical power gasped and stood up, watching as the paper crane was about to crash into the pavilion.

However, at the critical moment, an imperceptible breeze suddenly squeezed out from the gauze curtain, lifting a corner of the curtain while steadily holding the paper crane in mid-air.

Then the gentle breeze swirled, and the paper crane, as if encountering fierce fire, immediately turned to powder and scattered down into the crowd.

Everyone was dumbfounded, and at this moment, the curtain that had been covering everything suddenly opened from left and right. The first thing revealed was an exquisite small table filled with tea, snacks, fruits, and pots of sweet, fragrant fruit wine.

Then came a woman's ankles moving slightly up and down, with a string of copper bells hanging from her feet, making her legs appear straight and slender. The layered skirt embroidered with black flowers piled at the bottom of the chair, and silver chains hung from her waist, dividing the dark fabric into strips that glittered under the lights.

A silver palace cord hung from her waist with a miniature curved blade dangling from the end. Her chest was embroidered with silver thread forming skulls—mysterious and gorgeous.

This woman was undoubtedly alluring and dangerous, especially the pitch-black mask hanging around her slender neck, shaped like a fierce ghost with sharp fangs, making people shudder.

Chu Qingqiu's heartstrings immediately trembled. Her gaze pierced through the gaps in the gauze curtain, staring fixedly at the woman across from her. For some reason, this person gave her a strong sense of familiarity.

Could it be her? She gripped her sleeves tightly, thinking to herself.

But then the woman's actions dispelled such thoughts. She saw the woman pull a dancing girl by the sleeve to her side, then extended her left arm, and a beauty who had been lowering her head to pour wine stood up and sat down, leaning her boneless body into the woman's embrace with an upward smile.

It absolutely couldn't be Ning Fuyi. Ning Fuyi would never act in such a manner.

Chu Qingqiu suppressed the turmoil in her heart. She couldn't continue like this, seeing everyone as resembling her, as if she were possessed.

Besides her, everyone else was also very surprised, because no one had imagined that the mysterious and unpredictable Hall Master of Chuwei Hall would be such a woman.

Hua Hong, who had caused all this, was also stunned for a moment, then smiled and raised his cup, declaring loudly: "I am Hua Hong of the Flying Flower Sect. The mechanical artistry for entertainment just now wasn't perfected and nearly harmed a fellow immortal. I, Hua, borrow wine to apologize."

After speaking, he drained the wine in his hand and turned the cup upside down with a smile.

"No harm done." The woman spoke with a lazy, low voice that made people's bones tingle.

However, she didn't pick up her wine cup but instead, under everyone's watchful eyes, said something to the beauty in her arms that made the beauty laugh and melt into her embrace.

This made the other immortal sects blush and turn their gazes back to the high platform. Occasionally someone would whisper about the decline of moral standards, but they didn't dare speak too clearly.

They feared being targeted by this notoriously fierce hall master and bringing trouble upon themselves.

Hua Hong felt rebuffed, his face reddening slightly as he coldly threw down his wine cup. The handsome man behind him wanted to pour him more wine but received an angry rebuke: "What use are you? Get lost!"

Hua Feihua's hand stopped in mid-air. His eyes darkened for a moment, then he silently withdrew his hand and said nothing more.

"Sect Leader Hua Hong, please calm your anger. Though this person is somewhat promiscuous, she has no demonic aura about her and isn't the demon from the rumors. She probably just has an empty reputation and isn't worth our attention. We simply need not pay her any mind." Li Handin laughed sweetly.

Hua Hong forced a smile and nodded, no longer dwelling on the matter.